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California bills would make insurers cover more mental health

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State Sen. Scott Wiener, D-S.F., is co-author of SB854 and SB855.
Photo: Liz Hafalia / The Chronicle

California legislators on Tuesday introduced two bills aimed at improving access to mental health and addiction treatment by requiring health insurance companies to authorize some forms of treatment more quickly and to cover more comprehensive mental health services.

State Sens. Jim Beall, D-San Jose, and Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco, co-authored Senate Bill 854 and Senate Bill 855 — which both would apply to private health insurance plans only, and not to public insurance programs such as Medi-Cal, the joint federal and state health insurance program for low-income residents. The bills do not address how uninsured residents seek care.

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SB854 would prohibit insurance companies from directing patients with substance use disorders to first try other forms of treatment — such as group therapy or step therapy — before covering medication-assisted treatment, or MAT, if MAT is what their doctor recommends. MAT is becoming a more common form of treatment for opioid addiction, in which patients are prescribed opioid medication — at lower doses that don't induce a high — to wean them off of stronger opioids. It is done under the supervision of a physician and in conjunction with counseling and other behavioral health services.

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